

The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter



Photograph: AFP

America said it bombed radar and drone-control sites in **Iran** over the weekend, even as Donald Trump pondered the latest iteration of a proposed peace deal. As with other recent attacks, US Central Command called the actions “self-defence”. Iran said it had targeted an unspecified American air base in return. Kuwait, which houses several American military facilities, said that it had come under attack.

Israeli troops made their most significant incursion into **Lebanon** for decades, advancing near one of the country’s largest southern cities. The intention of Binyamin Netanyahu, Israel’s prime minister, is to “deepen and expand” Israel’s grip on places deemed to be under Hizbullah’s control. The Iran-backed militia, meanwhile, fired more than 300 projectiles at Israel. Israel and Lebanon agreed to a ceasefire in April.

The market capitalisation of **SoftBank**, a tech conglomerate, rose above ¥46trn (\$288bn), ending Toyota’s 23-year reign as Japan’s most valuable company. [Japanese carmakers](#) have struggled as Chinese electric vehicles gained market share. SoftBank, meanwhile, has bet big on artificial intelligence. On Sunday it

announced that it would commit €75bn (\$87bn) to building Europe's largest data-centre network in France.

Abelardo de la Espriella, a hard-right lawyer and Trump-lover, won the first round of **Colombia's** presidential election. "El Tigre", as he calls himself, will face Iván Cepeda, a hard-left candidate, in a run-off. President Gustavo Petro, who backs Mr Cepeda, said he "did not accept" the result, citing unsubstantiated irregularities. The election will signal whether the right-wing wave sweeping Latin America [has crested](#).

Berkshire Hathaway bought Taylor Morrison, an American homebuilder, for \$8.5bn. It is Greg Abel's first big acquisition since replacing Warren Buffett as the investment firm's head this year. The choice will be familiar to investors in Berkshire Hathaway, which often shuns tech firms in favour of old-fangled companies, and already owns shares in several construction firms. (Although it did make billions betting on Apple.)

Jerome Powell said that if an American president succeeded in dismissing a Federal Reserve official that he disagreed with, subsequent administrations would follow suit. That would ultimately destroy the bank's credibility, the former central-bank chair warned. Mr Powell, whom Mr Trump consistently [tried to undermine](#), voiced his concerns while receiving the John F. Kennedy Profile in Courage award.

At least 55 people were killed and dozens injured by an explosion in a village in Namhkam township, **Myanmar**. The area is controlled by the Ta'ang National Liberation Army, one of the most powerful armed groups opposing the country's ruling military junta. In a statement the TNLA blamed explosives used in mining. Many of Myanmar's rebel groups fund their campaigns by mining precious minerals.

Figure of the day: \$1.8trn. The commercial space sector's annual sales in 2035, as estimated by the World Economic Forum. But can businesses in orbit be taxed?



Photograph: Getty Images

Will Trump put his money where his mouth is?

On Friday America's president claimed—not for the first time—that [a peace deal](#) with Iran was imminent. Three days after he said he was preparing for a “final determination”, nothing has been announced. Donald Trump does seem to have sent a draft agreement back to Iran with several proposed changes. But those demands are not known publicly, and administration officials tell contradictory stories.

Domestic politics may be the main reason. Whatever is agreed next would be an interim measure, probably one that sees both sides lift their naval blockades and some easing of sanctions against Iran. Mr Trump insisted on Friday that “no money will be exchanged until further notice”. But America will almost certainly have to unfreeze billions of dollars in Iranian assets trapped in foreign banks. That would carry uncomfortable echoes of the nuclear deal Barack Obama negotiated in 2015, which Mr Trump abrogated (and still regularly disparages). Some of his Republican allies would be furious. Ending the war may come at a hefty political price.



Photograph: Getty Images

Ethiopia's ersatz elections

Abiy Ahmed, the [prime minister of Ethiopia](#), claims that Monday's election will be a democratic milestone. Unlike during the last polls, held in 2021 at the height of a brutal civil war, most of Africa's second-most populous country is now safe enough to allow citizens to vote, according to the government. Officially, at least 50m have registered (of 130m Ethiopians in total). So have more than 11,000 candidates from 47 parties.

In reality, the stage is set for what may be Africa's most farcical election of 2026. Polls will not be held in 46 of Ethiopia's 500-plus electoral districts—including parts of the regions of Amhara, where rebellion is escalating, and Tigray, whose ruling party has been outlawed after waging war on the federal government. Mr Abiy's main rivals have all been co-opted, imprisoned or exiled. His mother once prophesied he would be a king; fittingly, the election is shaping up to be a coronation.



Photograph: Reuters

More money, more problems in South Korea

South Korean chipmakers have done well from the artificial-intelligence boom. Samsung Electronics and SK Hynix—two of just three companies capable of making AI memory chips at scale—reached market valuations of \$1trn in May. Data released on Monday show that semiconductor shipments nearly tripled that month compared with May 2025. That drove South Korea’s exports up by 53.2% over the same period, to \$87.7bn.

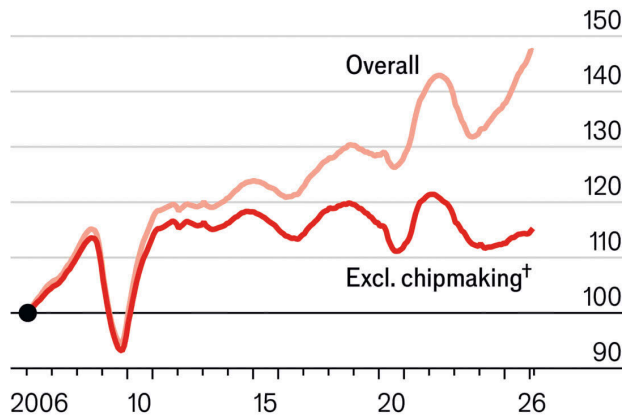
Chip workers won their share. In May unionised members at [Samsung](#) called off a strike in exchange for bonuses of more than 10% of its semiconductor division’s operating profits. SK Hynix agreed to a similar deal last year. Those payouts have sparked debates about widening inequality in South Korea.

Policymakers have been cautious, especially ahead of local elections on Wednesday. After a top official mused about redistributing AI’s windfall through a “citizen dividend”, stocks slumped. He was pilloried. The labour ministry postponed a discussion about sharing profits more evenly. Prosperity has its pitfalls.

Cash in chips

North-east Asia*, industrial production

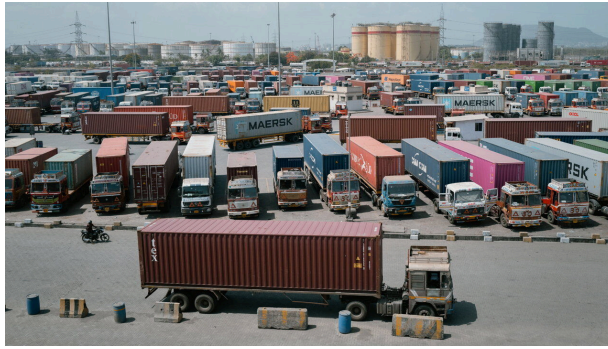
January 2006=100, 12-month moving average



*Japan, South Korea and Taiwan average

[†]Chipmaking includes production of semiconductors (all countries), servers (Taiwan), packaging (Taiwan) and chipmaking equipment (Japan)

Sources: National statistics; Haver Analytics



Photograph: Eyevine

Can America and India finally ink a trade deal?

American negotiators travel to New Delhi this week to potentially finalise an “interim agreement” on trade, and to start working towards a permanent one. After Donald Trump began his second term, talks between the countries became bogged down over areas such as farming (India wants to keep imports out). America blinked first: in February the White House agreed to lower its tariffs on India from 50% to 18%. The administration said that India had committed to buying at least \$500bn of American goods over the next five years in exchange—a stretch given that India bought \$45bn-worth in 2025.

The pressure on [India's government](#) to strike a quick deal has lessened. Later in February America's Supreme Court declared many of Mr Trump's original tariffs unconstitutional. (And a big chunk of Indian exports, such as smartphones and generic pharmaceuticals, were exempt anyway.) American negotiators will arrive in India's capital with far less leverage than they might like.



Photograph: Getty Images

Marilyn Monroe's 100-year itch

Ever since Norma Jeane, a young actress, assumed a more glamorous moniker in the 1940s, there have been many Marilyn Monroes. Next came Hollywood Marilyn and, soon enough, sex-symbol Marilyn. This year there are celebrations of all these iterations, for Monday marks the centenary of Monroe's birth. There are exhibitions, books and film screenings, commemorative auctions and new products from champagne to fine china.

Much like Monroe herself, the adoration has been [carefully constructed](#). Much of the centenary was planned by the firm that owns the rights to Monroe's estate and intellectual property. After it was founded in 2010, Monroe's was the first celebrity estate Authentic Brands Group acquired; it alone brings in \$80m in sales each year, according to the company. (Its portfolio now also includes Elvis Presley.)

Monroe once said that she belonged "to the public and to the world". Thanks to Authentic, people will continue to know her—whether as a film star or the beautiful face on a bottle of champagne—for as long as they are willing to pay.



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 BST on Friday to [\[email protected\]](#). We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Monday: The British ships *HMS Erebus* and *HMS Terror* were lost in 1845 in the attempt to navigate which waterway?

*Half of life's heartaches come
from decisions made in a hurry.*

Marilyn Monroe